ANTH 104-006: LANGUAGE, CULTURE, AND SOCIETY

Fall 2026 | 56891

Dr. Keisha I. Wiel
Mo/We: 1:40–2:55PM
Room: Powdermaker 116
Email: Keisha.Wiel@qc.cuny.edu
Office: Powdermaker Hall 315H
Office Hours: 12:00PM–1:00PM M/W

Course Description

Language plays a very important role in our everyday life. Not only is linguistic behavior the central focus of many social settings, but it is also on linguistic evidence that we base many of our evaluations of the world around us. Yet attitudes towards language and the ways in which we use language are highly dependent on social and cultural factors. This course introduces the field of linguistic anthropology: the study of language use in its socio-cultural context from anthropological perspectives. It focuses on the relationships among language, culture, and society by addressing such questions as: To what extent does language shape our thoughts and identities? Who are native speakers of a language? Do all children follow the same language acquisition patterns within a society or across cultures? What is sign language? How do languages develop and change? What are the differences between language and dialect? How does language reinforce or challenge social inequality? What is the relationship between language and ethnic identity? Do women speak more politely than men? Do men and women miscommunicate? How do we study language use and attitudes? How do conversations work? Do we need English-Only laws in the United States? Why is Ebonics controversial? Should we do anything about disappearing languages? Is English going to be the world language? Examples of linguistic phenomena in ethnographic perspective are drawn from peoples around the world.

Course Goals

This course provides students with a general overview of the discipline of linguistic anthropology introducing its theoretical and methodological issues and central topics of its concern. Numerous case studies are used to illustrate the workings of language in its sociocultural context, the role of individual language users and social groups in sociolinguistic and linguistic change, and how linguists and anthropologists engage real world issues. We address commonly held misconceptions about language and explore important issues related to linguistic diversity and the politics of language across cultures.

- Students will learn to identify and apply the concepts and methods of linguistic anthropology to understand the relationship between language, culture, and society.
- Students will learn to analyze individual language use and examine how an individual's place in society affects their language experiences, values, and practices.
- Students will learn to analyze local, national, and global movements and ideologies and analyze their impact on linguistic choices made by individuals and social groups, and on sociolinguistic developments in different societies.
- Students will examine different points of views, disciplinary research traditions, and data sources and collection methods, and how they relate to the understanding of language in socio-cultural context.
- Students will learn to evaluate evidence and arguments critically and analytically, and to marshal evidence to support well-reasoned arguments that address descriptive, interpretive, and policy concerns at stake in the study of language in its socio-cultural context.

Pathways: This course also satisfies the College's Pathways College Option – Language (QNSLANG) or the flexible core area of the Individual and Society (IS) with its outcomes 1,2,3,4, and 5.

- IS 1: Identify and apply the fundamental concepts and methods of a discipline or interdisciplinary field exploring the relationship between the individual and society, including, but not limited to, anthropology, communications, cultural studies, history, journalism, philosophy, political science, psychology, public affairs, religion, and sociology.
- IS 2: Examine how an individual's place in society affects experiences, values, or choices. IS 3: Articulate and assess ethical views and their underlying premises.
- IS 4: Articulate ethical uses of data and other information resources to respond to problems and questions.
- IS 5: Identify and engage with local, national, or global trends or ideologies, and analyze their impact on individual or collective decision-making.

Required Readings

All readings will be available on Brightspace. There will also be video and audio media that will supplement the readings for the week.

CUNY Policies

CUNY policy on Academic Integrity: The CUNY Policy on Academic Integrity, as adopted by the CUNY Board of Trustees, is available to all students. Academic dishonesty is prohibited in the City University of New York and is punishable by penalties, including failing grades, suspension, and expulsion. Academic Integrity Policy.

Artificial Intelligence (AI): Papers that are composed with the help of artificial intelligence like ChatGPT must include attribution.

Use of Student Work: All programs in New York State undergo periodic reviews by accreditation agencies. For these purposes, samples of student work are occasionally made available to those professionals conducting the review. Anonymity is assured under these circumstances. If you do not wish to have your work made available for these purposes, please let the professor know before the start of the second class. Thank you for your cooperation.

Accomodations for Students with Disabilities: Students with disabilities needing academic accommodations should register with and provide documentation to the Office of Special Services, Frese Hall, Room 111. The Office of Special Services will provide a letter for you to bring to your instructor indicating the need for accommodation and the nature of it. This should be done during the first week of class. For more information about the services available to Queens College students, contact the Office of Special Services by phone at 718-997-5870 or visit their webpage at Special Services.

Course Evaluations: During the final four weeks of the semester, you will be asked to complete an evaluation for this course by filling out an online questionnaire. Please remember to participate in these course evaluations. Your comments are highly valued, and these evaluations are an important service to fellow students and to the institution since your responses will be pooled with those of other students. Please also note that all responses are completely anonymous; identifying information is erased once the evaluation has been submitted.

Writing Center: The Writing Center offers writing tutoring and writing workshops to all undergraduate students currently enrolled in classes. I encourage everyone to utilize its services for the essay assignment.

Assignments and Grading

Class participation: This course emphasizes discussion of assigned readings and collective analysis of documents, videos, and images presented in the classroom. Your participation is, therefore, necessary. You are required not only to complete the readings, but also to verbally

express your responses to them in class. A rubric outlining participation expectation will be provided on the first day of class.

Weekly Observations: You will write short observation responses on the readings and discussions of the week. More information will be given during class.

Midterm Project (Ethnographic Vibes): You will write a short analysis on a theme covered in class and then you will curate a playlist to complement the reading. More information will be given later.

Final Project (Multimedia Project): For this assignment, you are asked to create a multimedia blog containing 8 to 10 posts on Tumblr, TikTok, Instagram, etc. You will need to incorporate at least **2 academic sources** for each post that is related to a topic that we have covered. More information on this project will be posted on Canvas. You will use **information literacy** to identify and appropriately incorporate academic sources and develop **communication skills** as you create your multimedia presentation to share with your peers.

Class Participation 20%
Weekly Observation Posts 30%
Midterm Project 25%
Final 25%

This is the grading set forth by the university:			
A+ 97-100	**B+** 87-89	**C+** 77-79	**D+** 67-69
A 93-96	**B** 83-86	**C** 73-76	**D** 60-66
A- 90-92	**B-** 80-82	**C-** 70-72	**F** 0-59

Schedule: *Subject to Change*

Week 1:	August 31st	• Syllabus and course overview
	September 2nd	• Chapter 1: The Socially Charged Life of Language
Week 2:	September 7th	**NO CLASS**
	September 9th	• Chapter 2: Gestures, Sign Languages, and Multimodality

Week 3:	September 14th	• Chapter 3: The Research Process of Linguistic Anthropology
	September 16th	• Garcia-Sánchez- "Learning about Children's Lives: A Note on Methodology" *Language and Muslim Immigrant Childhoods: The Politics of Belonging*
Week 4:	September 21st	**NO CLASS**
	September 23rd	• Chapter 4: Language Acquisition and Socialization
Week 5:	September 28th	**NO CLASS**
	September 30th	• Paugh- "Negotiating Language Ideologies through Imaginary Play: Children's Code Choice and Rescaling Practices in Dominica, West Indies"
Week 6:	September 5th	• Chapter 5: Language, Thought, and Culture
	October 7th	• Degraff- "Creole Exceptionalism and the (Mis)Education of the Creole Speaker" *The Languages of Africa and the Diaspora*
Week 7:	October 12th (October 13th)	**NO CLASS: CLASS ON OCTOBER 13th** • Chapter 6: Global Communities of Multilingual Language Users
	October 14th	• Wiel- "Linguistic Bias or a Chance to Get Ahead: Linguistic Repertoires in Aruban and Curaçaoan Schools" *Ethnographic Insights on Latin America and the Caribbean*
Week 8:	October 19th	• Chapter 7: Literacy Practices
	October 21st	• Chapter 8: Online Communities and Internet Linguistic Practices • **MIDTERM PROJECT DUE**
Week 9:	October 26th	**NO CLASS**
	October 28th	• Phyak- "(En)Countering Language Ideologies: Language Policing in the Ideospace of Facebook"
Week 10:	November 2nd	**NO CLASS**

	November 4th	• Chapter 9: Performance, Performativity, and the Constitution of Communities
Week 11:	November 9th	• Zentalla- "Dime con Quién Hablas, y te Diré Quién Eres": Linguistic (In)security and Latina/o Unity"
	November 11th	• Chapter 10: Language and Gender • **WATCH**: Paris is Burning
Week 12:	November 16th	• hooks- "Is Paris Burning?" [Black Looks: Race and Representation] • **WATCH**: Paris is Burning
	November 18th	• Chapter 11: Language, Race, and Ethnicity
Week 13:	November 23rd	• Smalls and Davis- "Language and Racism" • **WATCH**: Save by the Bell (Season 2, Episode 7: La Guerra de Aisha)
	November 25th	**NO CLASS**
Week 14:	November 30th	• Chapter 12: Language Endangerment and Revitalization • **WATCH**: We Still Live Here: Âs Nutayuneân
	December 2nd	**NO CLASS**
Week 15:	December 7th	• Perley- "Zombie Linguistics: Experts, Endangered Languages and the Curse of the Undead Voices"
	December 9th	• Chapter 13: Conclusion: Language, Power, and Agency
Week 16:	December 14th	• García- "Translanguaging in Schools: Subiendo y Bajando, Bajando y Subiendo as Afterward" • Alim- "Global Hip Hop: Style, Language, and Globalization" *A New Companion to Linguistic Anthropology*
	December 19th	**FINAL PROJECT DUE**